

◆ HERALDIC QUILT BLOCK SERIES ◆



FINISHED SIZES

14" x 14"

12" x 12"

8" x 8"



SKILL LEVEL
BEGINNER



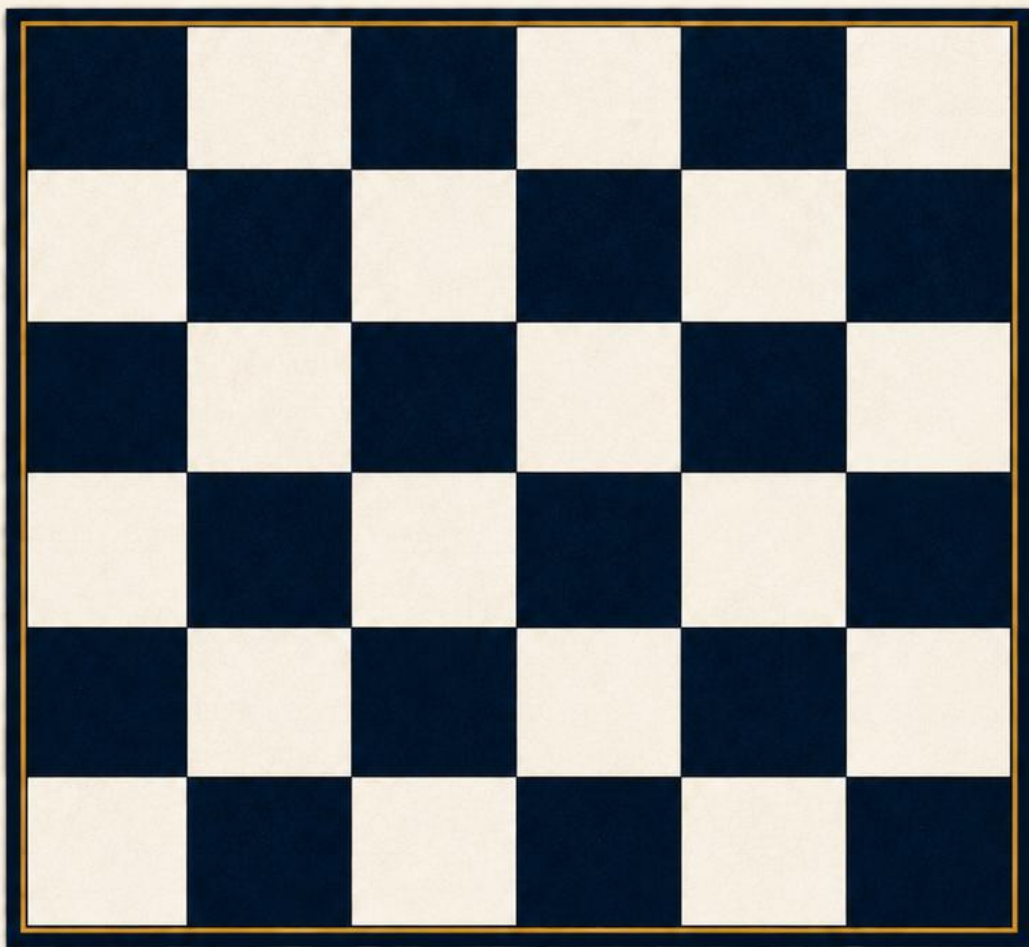
STRIP-PIECED
CONSTRUCTION



CLEAR, STEP-BY-STEP
INSTRUCTIONS

A HERALDIC CHECKY QUILT BLOCK PATTERN

A Traditional Heraldic Checkerboard Quilt Block



— TIMELESS • CLASSIC • VERSATILE —

DESIGNED BY PAULINE KURDT
OF KAT'S KUSTOM KRAFTS, L.L.C.

PATTERN VERSION 1.0

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Introduction

Welcome to **A Heraldic Checky Quilt Block Pattern**, a modern interpretation of one of the oldest geometric motifs found in European heraldry. The checky, or checkerboard, design has appeared on shields and coats of arms for centuries, admired for its bold symmetry and striking visual contrast.

This pattern transforms that timeless heraldic motif into a versatile 14-inch quilt block using only two contrasting fabrics and straight-line piecing. While the completed block has the appearance of many individually pieced squares, the construction method featured in this booklet uses efficient strip piecing to simplify cutting, improve accuracy, and speed assembly.

Whether you're creating a single decorative block, a coordinating pillow, or repeating the design across an entire quilt, this pattern offers a straightforward project with a polished result. The included Electric Quilt 8 diagrams provide the technical foundation for the block, while the step-by-step instructions guide you through a faster construction method designed for confident beginners and experienced quilters alike.

Take a few moments to review the materials, fabric requirements, and cutting instructions before you begin. Careful preparation and a consistent ¼-inch seam allowance will help ensure crisp intersections and a beautifully finished block.

Happy quilting!

Historical Background

The **checky** (also spelled **chequy**) field is one of the oldest and most recognizable patterns in European heraldry. Consisting of alternating squares arranged in a regular grid, it appeared on shields, banners, and seals during the High Middle Ages and became one of the classic heraldic field treatments rather than a design associated with a single individual or family.

In heraldic terminology, **checky** describes a field divided into equal squares of alternating tinctures (colors and metals). The pattern was widely used throughout England, Scotland, France, Germany, the Low Countries, and other parts of Europe. As heraldic arms were inherited, differenced, and adapted over generations, variations of the checky field appear in the arms of numerous noble families, municipalities, guilds, and historical institutions.

Unlike heraldic charges such as lions, eagles, or fleurs-de-lis, a checky field derives its visual impact from geometric repetition and strong contrast. Like many bold heraldic designs, its simple repeating structure is easily recognized at a distance, making it well suited to the identification role that coats of arms served on medieval battlefields and during tournaments.

The same qualities that made the design effective in heraldry also make it well suited to quilting. The alternating arrangement of light and dark fabrics creates striking contrast while relying on straightforward construction techniques. Although this pattern is inspired by historic heraldic art, it has been adapted for modern quilting using efficient strip-piecing methods while preserving the classic checkerboard appearance illustrated in the accompanying EQ8 block diagrams.

Today, heraldic-inspired quilt blocks provide a creative way to celebrate history, genealogy, and traditional design while producing timeless quilts that can be enjoyed for generations.

Did You Know?

- The heraldic term is **checky** (or **chequy**), not "checkerboard."
- Heraldic fields are described using specialized terminology called **blazon**.
- The checky pattern has been in continuous use for more than 700 years.
- Many medieval coats of arms use the checky field as the entire shield design rather than as a background for additional symbols.

Materials & Tools

Before you begin, gather the following materials and tools. Using quality supplies and accurate cutting tools will help ensure crisp points and matching seams.

Fabrics

1. Fabric A – Dark Fabric
2. Fabric B – Light Fabric

Thread

- 100% cotton piecing thread
- Neutral gray, cream, or a color that blends with both fabrics

Sewing Supplies

You'll need:

- Rotary cutter with a sharp blade
- Self-healing cutting mat
- Acrylic quilting ruler
- Sewing machine capable of an accurate ¼" seam
- ¼" presser foot (recommended)
 - I use a blind hem foot and a seam guide.
- Fine glass-head or patchwork pins (optional)
- Fabric marking pencil (optional)
- Seam ripper
- Small scissors or thread snips (If your machine does not automatically snip the threads.)

Pressing Tools

- Steam iron
- Ironing board or pressing mat
- Spray starch or pressing spray (optional)
 - Light starching before cutting can improve accuracy and reduce fabric distortion.

Recommended Notions

Although not required, these tools can make construction easier:

- Seam guide for maintaining a consistent ¼" seam
- Rotating cutting mat
- Mini iron for pressing small sections
- Quilting clips for organizing rows

Before You Begin

- ✓ Prewash fabrics if desired.
- ✓ Press fabrics before cutting.
- ✓ Use a consistent ¼" seam allowance throughout.
- ✓ Verify your ruler measurements before cutting.
- ✓ Read the entire pattern before beginning.

Fabric Requirements and Estimated Yardages¹

Choose two fabrics with **strong value contrast** for the most striking checkerboard effect. A dark/light pairing will produce the classic heraldic appearance shown throughout this pattern.

Designer Tip

Before cutting, place your two fabrics side by side and view them in grayscale (or take a photo and remove the color). If the values are clearly different, the checkerboard pattern will stand out beautifully.

Materials

- Fabric A (Dark)
- Fabric B (Light)
- Coordinating cotton thread
- Rotary cutter, acrylic ruler, and cutting mat
- Sewing machine with a ¼" quilting foot
 - I use a blind hem foot and a seam guide set to ¼".
- Iron and pressing surface

Finished Block Size: 14" × 14"

Estimated Yardage

Fabric width 44-45 inches	Number of patches	Yardage estimate
	32	1/4
	32	1/4

Finished Block Size: 12" × 12"

Estimated Yardage

Fabric width 44-45 inches	Number of patches	Yardage estimate
	32	1/8
	32	1/8

Finished Block Size: 8" × 8"

Estimated Yardage

Fabric width 44-45 inches	Number of patches	Yardage estimate
	32	1/8
	32	1/8

Fabric Selection Suggestions

For the strongest visual impact:

- Use one **light** and one **dark** fabric.
- Solid fabrics or small-scale prints work best.
- Avoid two fabrics of similar value, as the checkerboard effect will be less distinct.
- If using directional prints, purchase additional fabric to allow for pattern matching.
- Use a consistent ¼" **seam allowance** throughout the project.

Recommended Construction Method

Although the block can be assembled by sewing the individual squares, this pattern recommends using the **strip-piecing method** for greater speed and improved accuracy.

Benefits include:

- Fewer individual seams to align
- Faster construction
- Better corner matching
- Improved seam nesting
- More consistent finished block size

Assembly Instructions

Before You Begin

For best results, use a consistent **$\frac{1}{4}$ inch seam allowance** throughout the project.

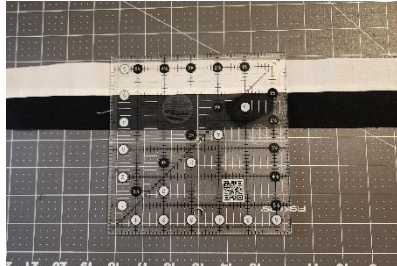
Accurate cutting is the foundation of a square, flat quilt block. Before cutting your fabrics, press both fabrics smooth and ensure the fabric is lying flat on your cutting mat.

1. Cut four fabric strips.
 - a. For the 14" x 14" block, 2½ inches wide in alternating colors (e.g., 2 of the light fabric and 2 of the dark fabric) the width of your fabric (44-45"). The 2 ½ inches makes a 2 inch finished block that includes $\frac{1}{4}$ inch seam allowance on each side.
 - b. For the 12" x 12" block, 2 inches wide in alternating colors (e.g., 2 of the light fabric and 2 of the dark fabric) the width of your fabric (44-45"). The 2 inches makes a 1½ inch finished block that includes $\frac{1}{4}$ inch seam allowance on each side.
 - c. For the 8" x 8" block, 1½ inches wide in alternating colors (e.g., 2 of the light fabric and 2 of the dark fabric) the width of your fabric (44-45"). The 1½ inches makes a 1 inch finished block that includes $\frac{1}{4}$ inch seam allowance on each side.

2. Sew one strip of light fabric to one strip of the dark fabric, lengthwise using a consistent $\frac{1}{4}$ inch seam allowance. Repeat with the other strips of light and dark fabric.



3. Press the seams towards the dark fabric.
4. Cut the sewn strips in half across the sewn strips.



5. Sew half strips together alternating colors.



6. Once your strip set is sewn, lay it flat on your cutting mat.
7. Square off one short end of the strip set, cut the strip at $2\frac{1}{2}$ inches.
8. Each of these segments now represent one row of your block.
9. Lay out your 8 row segments in front of you.

10. Arrange them in a checkerboard pattern by flipping and rotating every other row.



11. Sew the 8 rows together. Because you pressed all your row seams in one direction in Step 1, the seams on adjacent rows will naturally nest into each other, eliminating bulk and matching corners flawlessly.

12. Press the final block flat.

About the Designer

Pauline Kurdt is the owner of **Kat's Kustom Krafts, L.L.C.** and has a passion for combining traditional heraldry with modern quilt design. Drawing inspiration from historic armorial art, she creates quilt patterns that celebrate history while remaining approachable for today's quilters.

Each pattern in the **Heraldic Quilt Series** begins with historical research and is carefully adapted into quilt blocks that emphasize clean construction, efficient piecing methods, and timeless design.

Thank you for supporting independent quilt pattern designers.

Pauline Kurdt

Kat's Kustom Krafts, L.L.C.

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If you discover an error or have questions about the instructions, please contact:

Pattern updates and corrections will be available through the designer's website.

Acknowledgements

This pattern would not have been the same without the encouragement of two wonderful friends.

Carolyn James was instrumental in getting me to step away from the virtual world and start quilting in the real one. She graciously read through this pattern with a beginner's eye and continually reminded me to keep the instructions clear, simple, and welcoming for new quilters.

Suzanne Wheatly, my quilting mentor, has been generous with both her time and her expertise, sharing her knowledge, years of experience, and passion for quilting. Her encouragement, thoughtful advice, and dedication to the craft have helped me grow in both confidence and skill, and I am deeply grateful for her encouragement along the way.

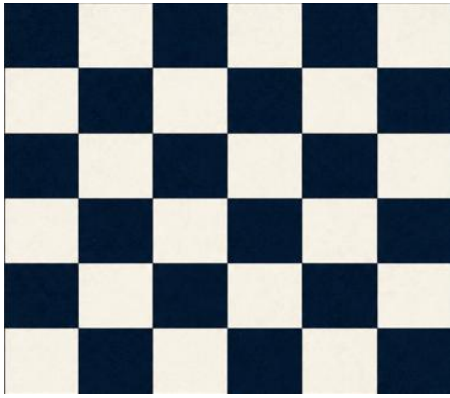
Constructing the Block Using the Templates¹

1. Print the templates.
 - a. Decide which size block you would like to make and print that page at **100% (Actual Size)**.
 - b. Do **not** use:
 - i. Fit to Page
 - ii. Scale to fit
 - iii. Shrink to Printable Area
2. Verify the template.
 - a. Before cutting fabric, verify that the printed template measures correctly. If the template does not measure correctly, adjust your printer settings and print again before continuing.

Finished Block Size	Template Measurement (solid line to solid line)
14" x 14"	2"
12" x 12"	1½"
8" x 8"	1"

3. Prepare Your Fabric
 - a. Select two fabrics with strong value contrast.
 - b. Press both fabrics flat before cutting.
 - c. If desired, lightly starch the fabric to improve cutting accuracy.
4. Trace or Use the Template
 - a. Place the template on the wrong side of the fabric.
 - b. You may:
 - i. Trace around the template using a removable fabric marker, or
 - ii. Use the template directly as a cutting guide with a rotary cutter.
 - c. Repeat until all required pieces have been cut.
5. Cut the Required Squares
 - a. Cut the following quantities:
 - i. Fabric A (Dark) - 32 squares
 - ii. Fabric B (Light) - 32 squares
 - b. Total pieces required - 64 squares
6. Arrange the Layout
 - a. Lay all pieces onto a design wall or other flat surface.

- b. Arrange them according to the checkerboard layout shown in the block diagram.



- c. Begin with a dark square in the upper-left corner.
d. Alternate light and dark fabrics across every row.
e. Reverse the starting color on each successive row.
f. Before sewing, verify that every adjacent square contrasts in color.

7. Piece the Rows

- a. Sew the first row from left to right.
b. Continue sewing each remaining row individually.
c. Press the seams toward the darker fabric after completing each row.

8. Join the Rows

- a. Match the seams carefully.
b. Pin at every seam intersection if desired.
c. Sew the rows together sequentially.
d. Because adjacent rows have opposing seam directions, the seams should nest together naturally.

9. Final Pressing

- a. Press the completed block flat without stretching the fabric.

Template Pages

The following pages contain printable templates for each finished block size.

Use the template that corresponds to your desired finished block.

- [14" × 14"](#)
- [12" × 12"](#)
- [8" × 8"](#)

Store printed templates in a protective sleeve so they can be reused for future projects.

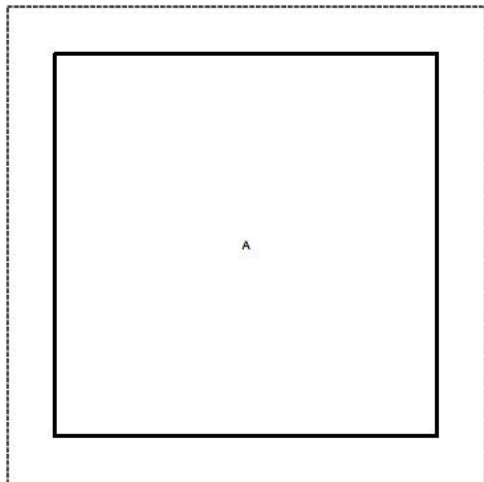
Designer Tip

Although template construction is traditional and works well for scrap quilting or fussy-cut fabrics, the strip-piecing method described earlier in this booklet is considerably faster for constructing multiple blocks while maintaining excellent accuracy.

Choose the method that best suits your quilting style and your project.

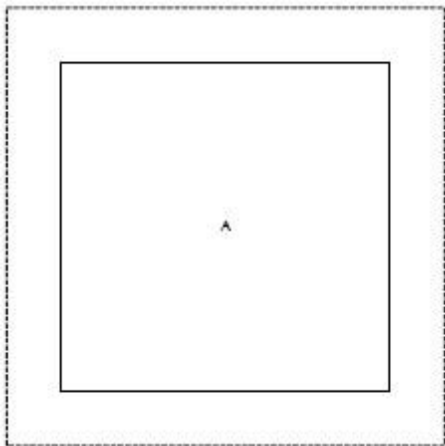
14" x 14" Template

The template should measure 2" from solid line to solid line.



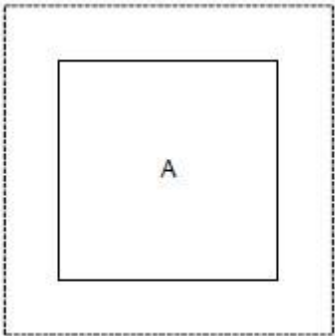
12" x 12" Template

The template should measure 1½" from solid line to solid line.



8" x 8" Template

The template should measure 1" from solid line to solid line.

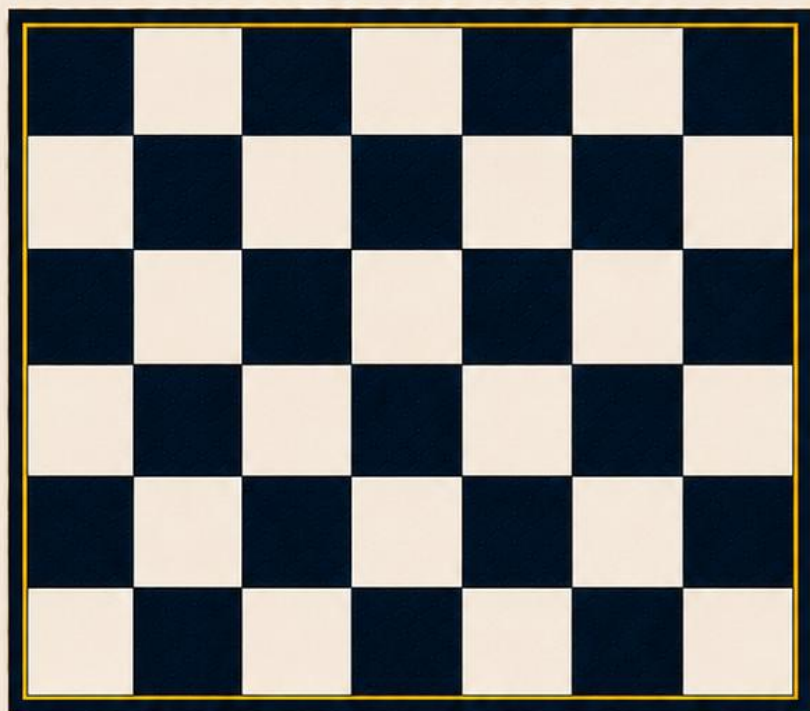


Endnotes

1. All fabric requirements, estimated yardages, block diagram, and templates were generated by Electric Quilt 8.

A HERALDIC CHECKY QUILT BLOCK PATTERN

*A timeless checkerboard design inspired by
centuries of European heraldry.*



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THREE FINISHED SIZES

14" x 14"

12" x 12"

8" x 8"



SKILL LEVEL
BEGINNER



STRIP PIECING
METHOD



CLEAR, STEP-BY-STEP
INSTRUCTIONS



TWO FABRICS
ENDLESS
POSSIBILITIES

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